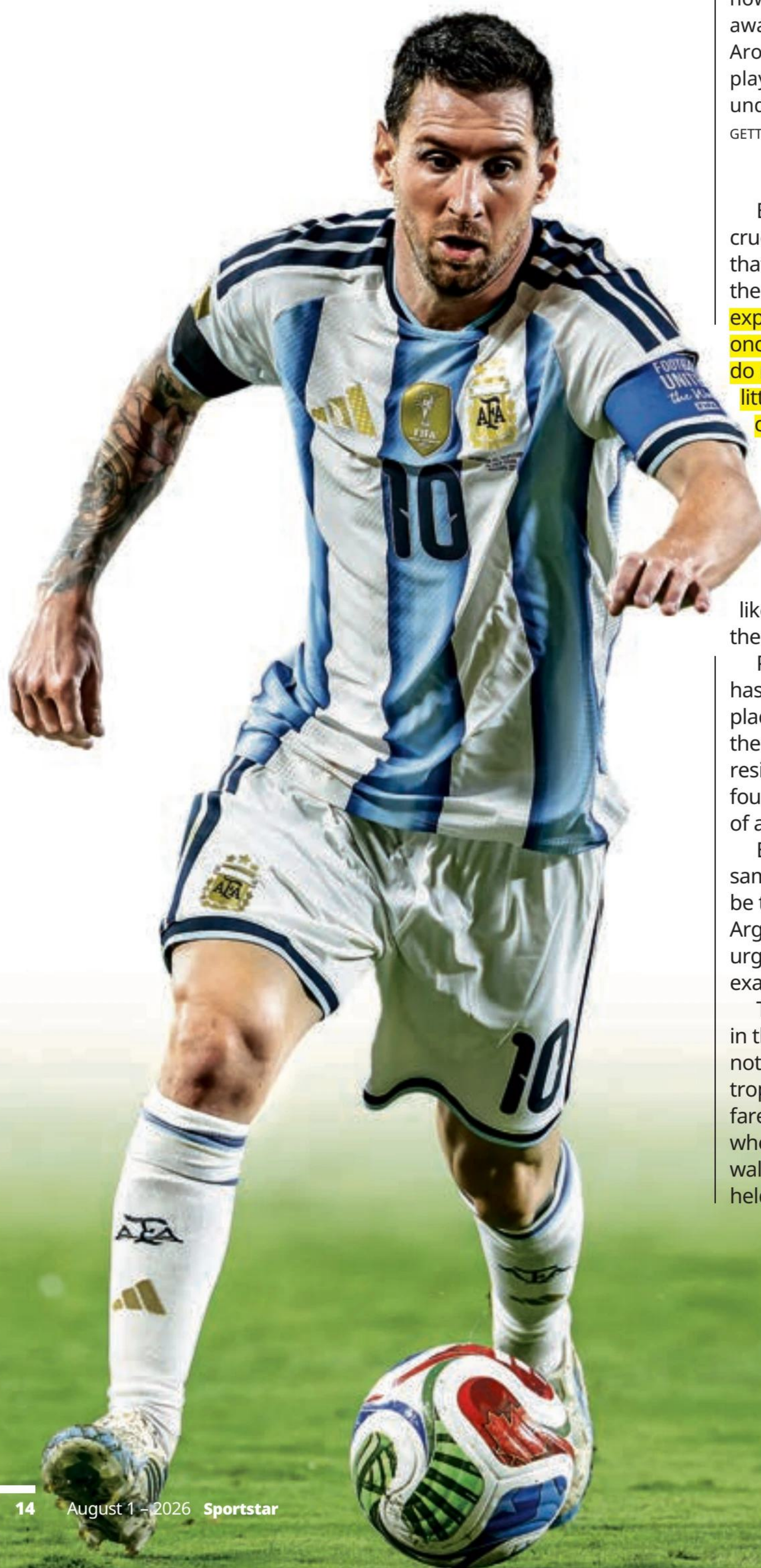




Waiting for the end: Lionel Messi feels like the last player still capable of resisting time itself. Every tournament now carries the same unspoken awareness: it could be the last chapter. Around him, Argentina has often played with the urgency of men who understand exactly what that means.

GETTY IMAGES

But sport, with its occasional cruelty, has a way of reminding us that permanence was never part of the bargain. **This World Cup has exposed the mortality of men who once seemed immune to it. The legs do not always obey. Recovery takes a little longer. The moments still come, but not always on command. The body, eventually, begins to negotiate with the mind.**

And so, one by one, the stars who seemed to live outside time have begun to look like what they always were beneath the myth: mere mortals.

Perhaps that is why Lionel Messi has come to occupy such a singular place in the imagination. He feels like the last player still capable of resisting time itself, as though he has found a private loophole in the laws of ageing.

Every tournament now carries the same unspoken awareness: it could be the last chapter. Around him, Argentina has often played with the urgency of men who understand exactly what that means.

There is something faintly familiar in the way teammates seem to rally not only around the pursuit of a trophy but around the dignity of a farewell, the desire to make sure that whenever their great man finally walks away, he does so with his head held high.